THE BOTTLENECK OF ONE: WHY YOUR MARKETING AI LEADER NEEDS BUILDERS



JESSICA HREHA

Director, Marketing AI Transformation

Veeam Software

MAICON FORWARD

#MAICON26

2023 The Internal AI Council

How and why to build one



vmware

veeam

2023

The Internal AI Council

How and why to build one

2024

Stuck in Experimentation Land

The AI Adoption Curve for marketing



jasper

veeam

2023 **The Internal AI Council**

How and why to build one

2024 **Stuck in Experimentation Land**

The AI Adoption Curve for marketing

2025 **The Missing Role in Marketing**

A dedicated AI transformation leader



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2023 **The Internal AI Council**

How and why to build one

2024 **Stuck in Experimentation Land**

The AI Adoption Curve for marketing

2025 **The Missing Role in Marketing**

A dedicated AI transformation leader

2026 **The Bottleneck of One**

Today: the receipts

1

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「If AI transformation is everyone's job,

"If AI transformation is everyone's job, it's no one's job.

Jessica Hreha, MAICON 2024



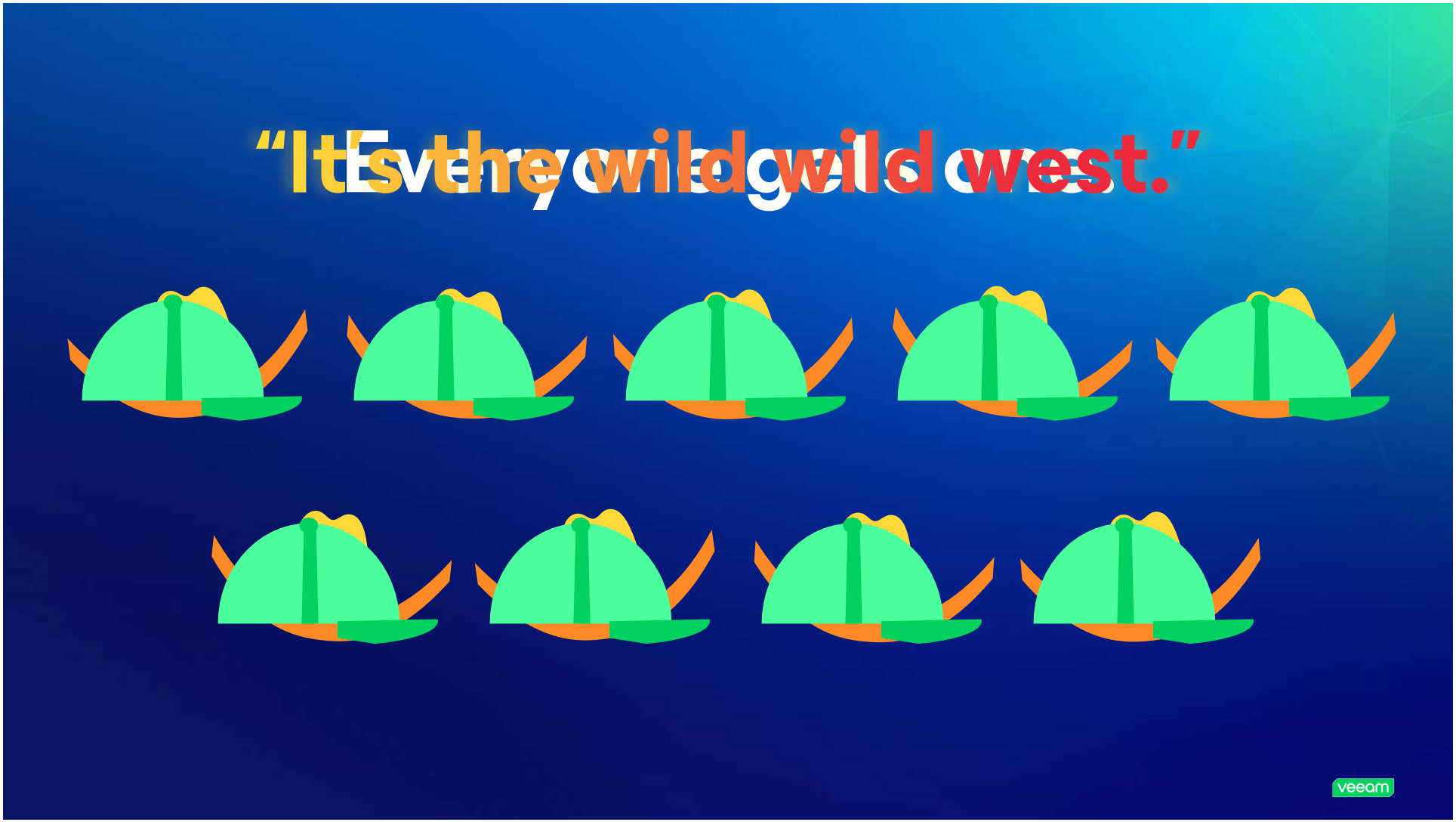
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A new hat for every role.

Rachel Woods, AI for B2B Summit

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“It’s the wild wild west.”
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June 2025

Veeam Software

Director, Marketing AI Transformation

Remote US · Full-time

Veeam Software

Director, Marketing AI Transformation

Remote US · Full-time

20+

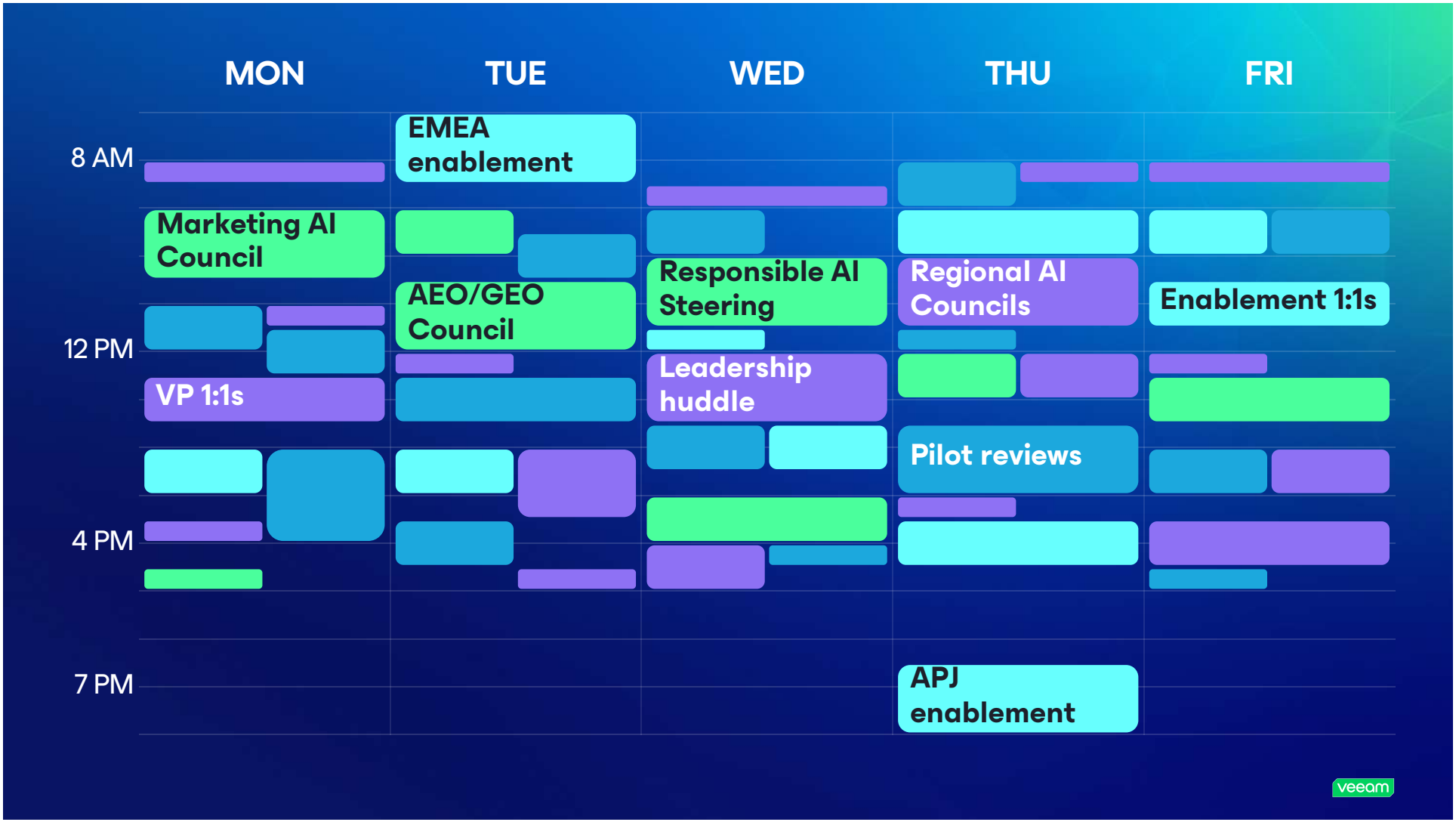
more companies posted the role since

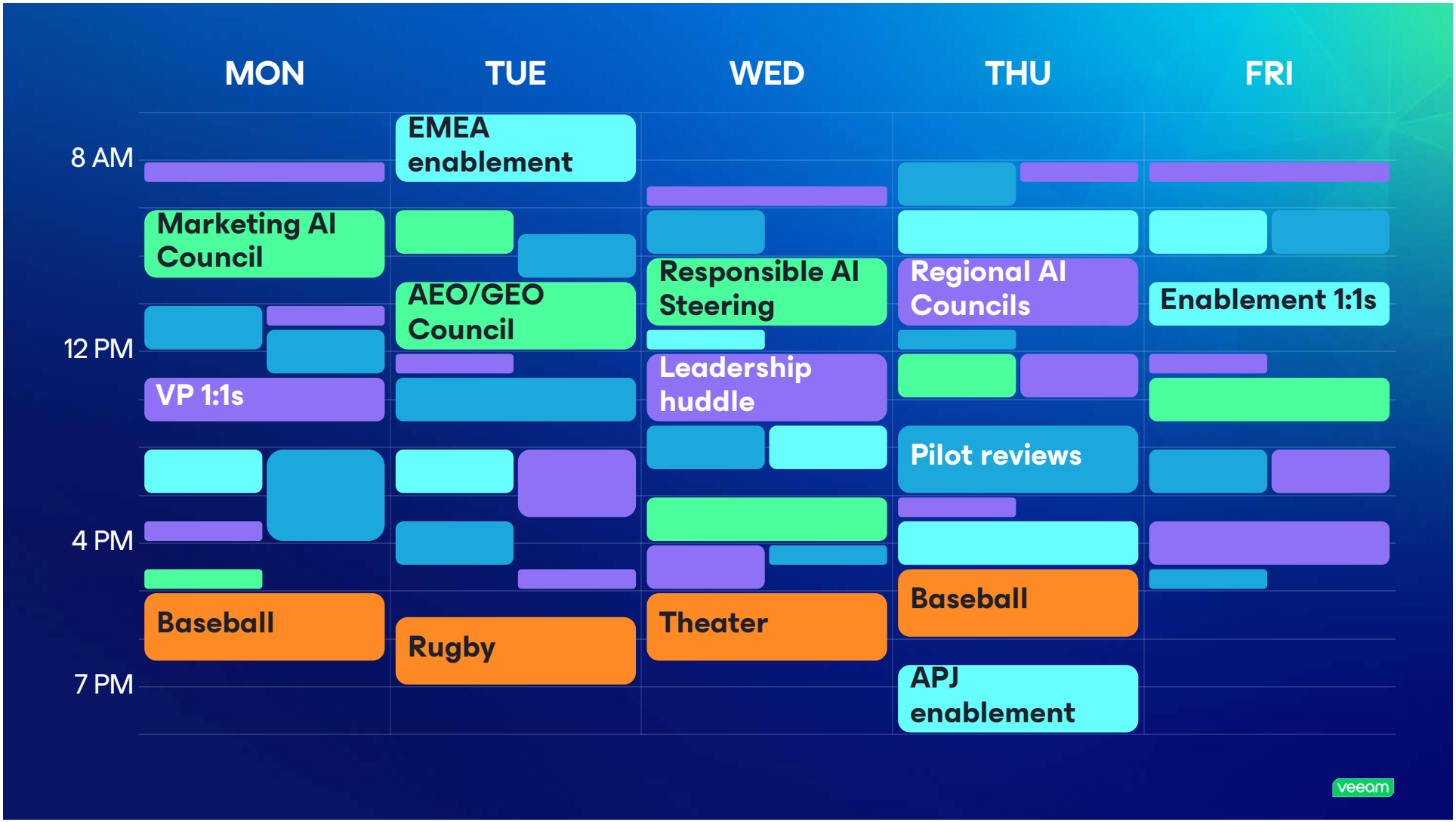
June 2025

Sept 2026

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Alignment
AI strategy and AEO/GEO
Governance
Responsible AI
Enablement
Literacy and operational rigor
Outcomes
ROI and business impact
Marketing AI Council
AEO/GEO council
Responsible AI Group
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MON
TUE
WED
THU
FRI
8 AM
12 PM
4 PM
7 PM
EMEA enablement
Marketing AI Council
AEO/GEO Council
Responsible AI Steering
Regional AI Councils
Enablement 1:1s
Leadership huddle
VP 1:1s
Pilot reviews
APJ enablement
veeam


MON
TUE
WED
THU
FRI
8 AM
12 PM
4 PM
7 PM
Marketing AI Council
VP 1:1s
Baseball
EMEA enablement
AEO/GEO Council
Rugby
Responsible AI Steering
Leadership huddle
Theater
Regional AI Councils
Pilot reviews
Baseball
APJ enablement
Enablement 1:1s
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Every meeting is leading.

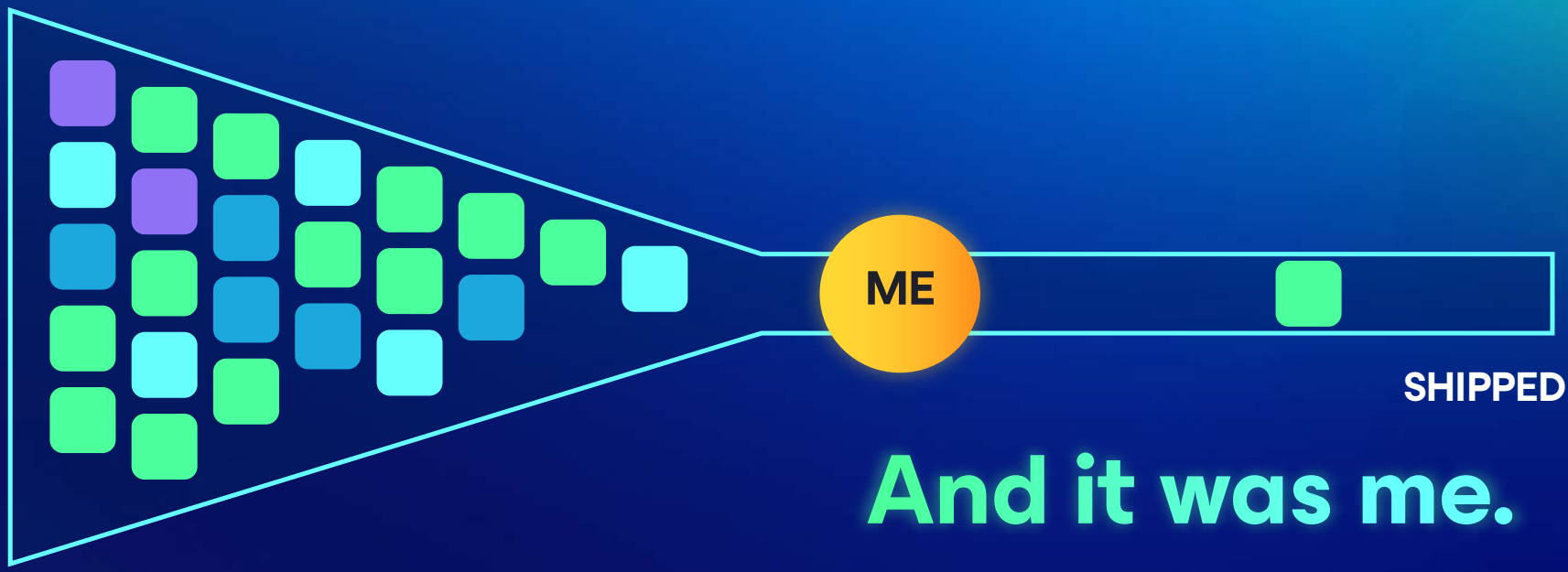
LEADING

Not one is building.

BUILDING

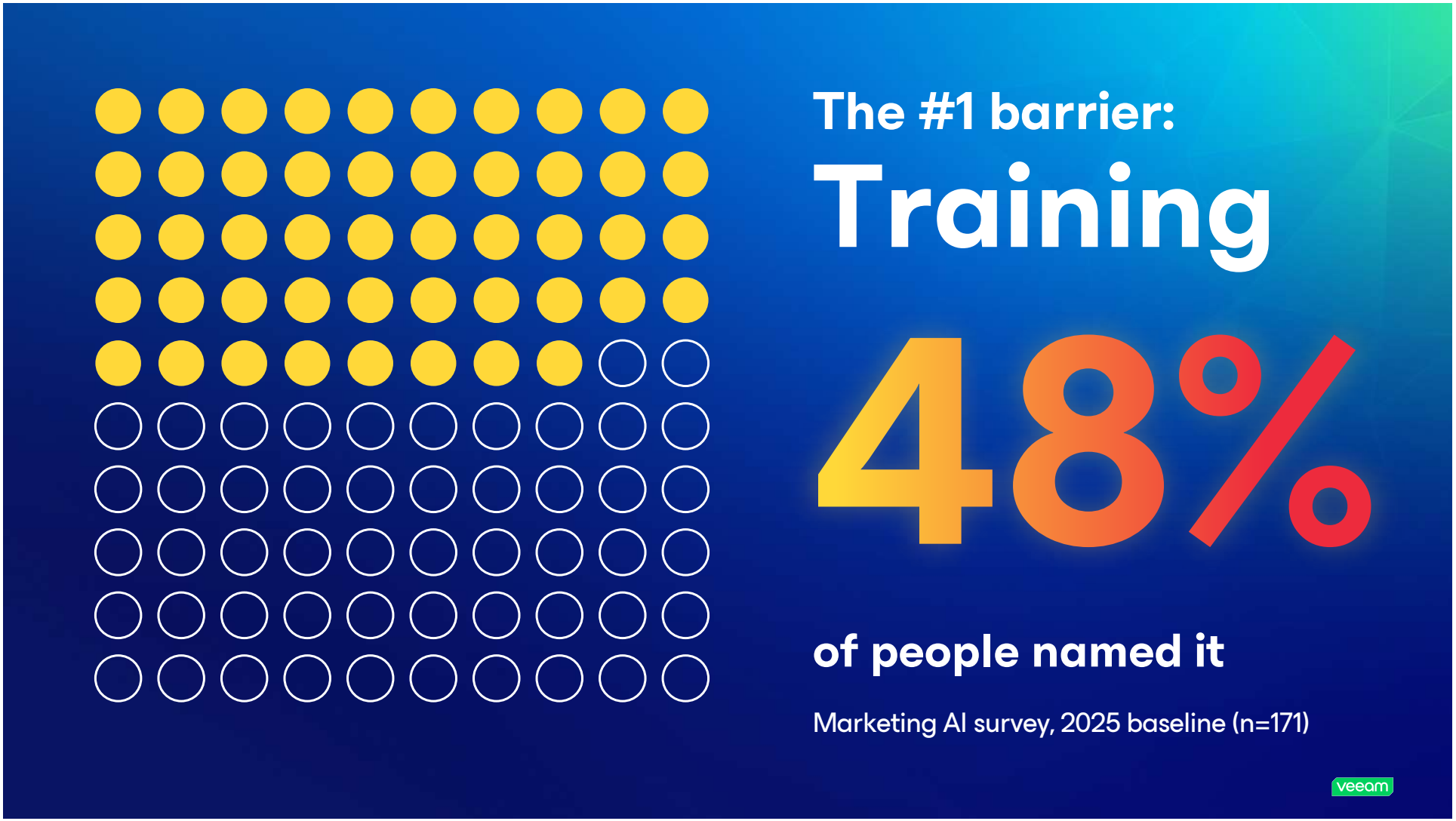
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A bottleneck of one.



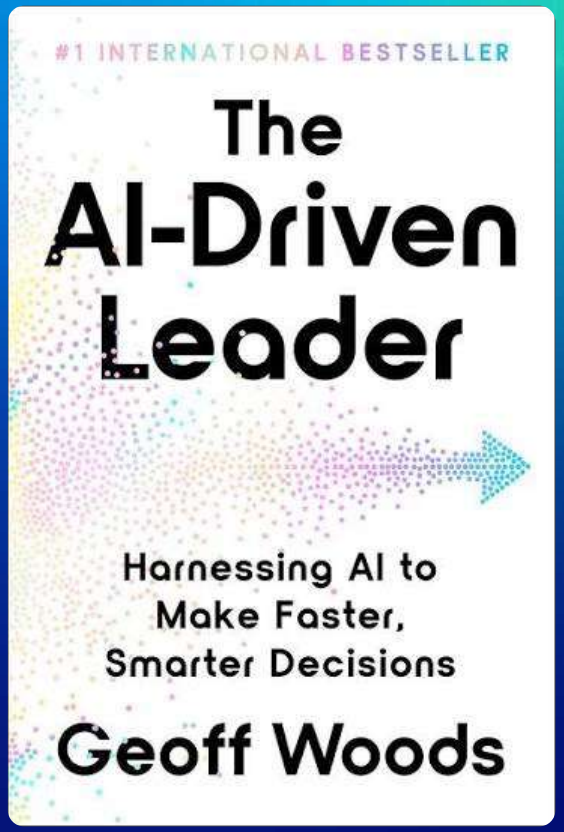
And it was me.

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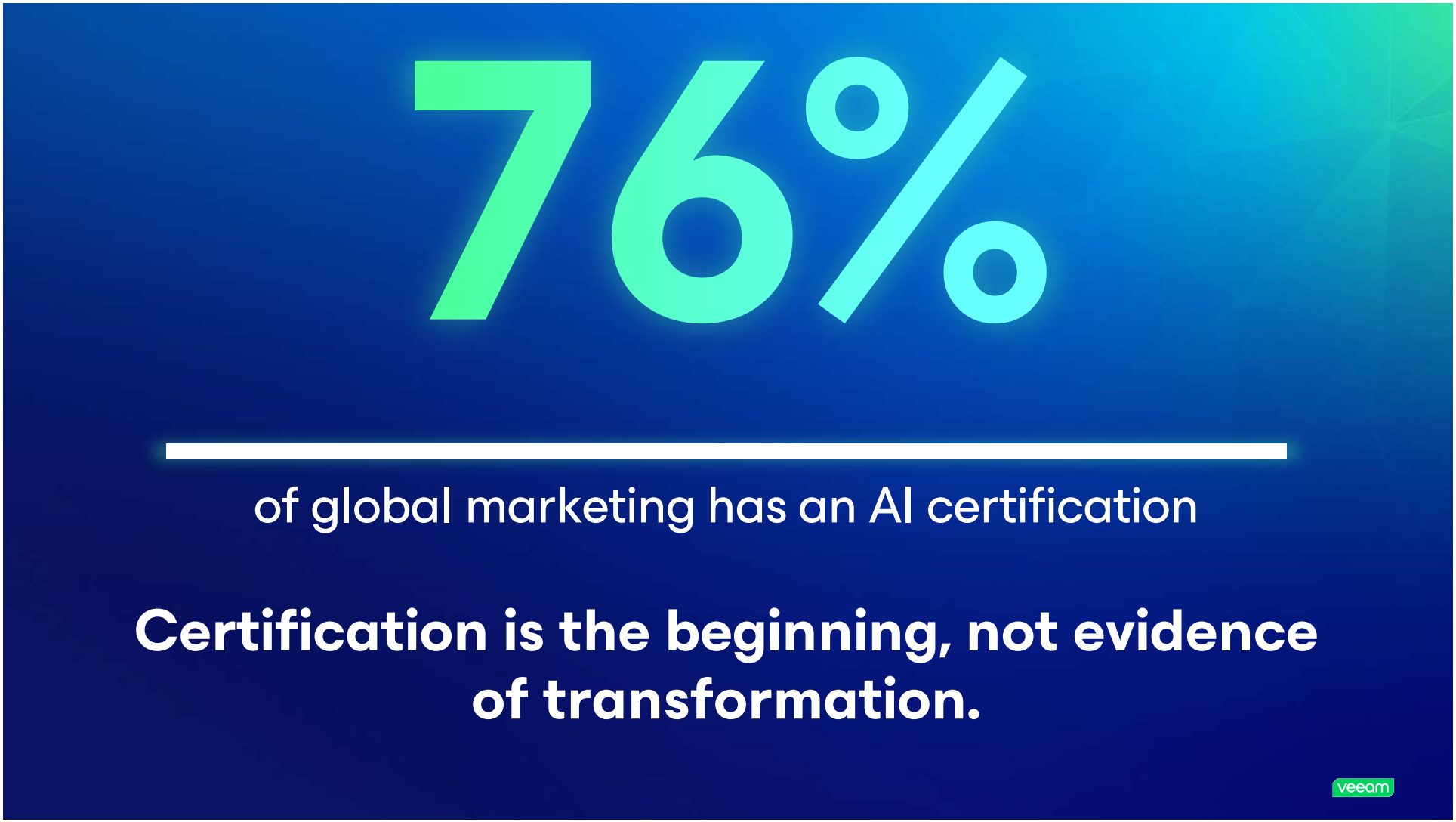

The #1 barrier:
Training
48%
of people named it
Marketing AI survey, 2025 baseline (n=171)
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Literacy first.

- LinkedIn Learning certifications
- AI in Action/Exchange sessions
- GMO AI Council (Champions)
- Book club



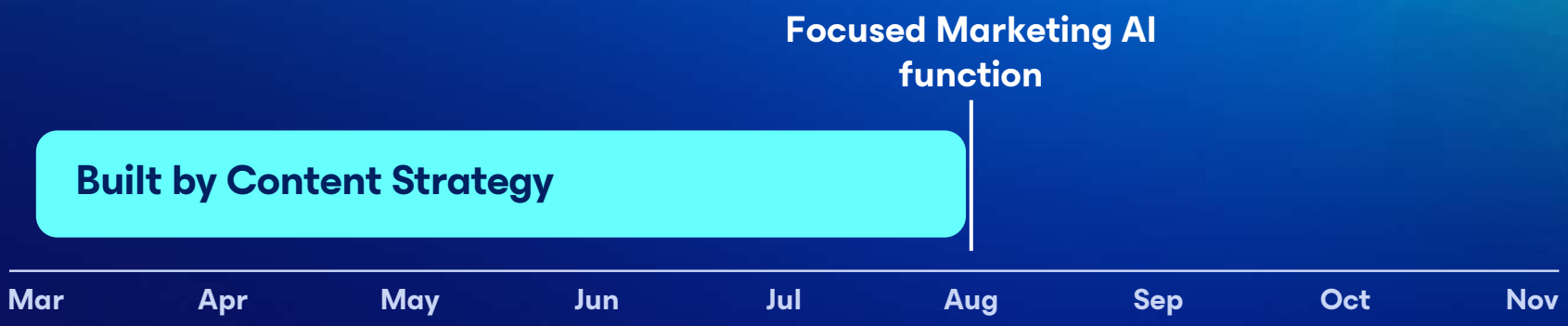

76%
of global marketing has an AI certification
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76%
of global marketing has an AI certification
Certification is the beginning, not evidence of transformation.
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None of it ships a workflow.

Content Coach

Writes and checks copy in Veeam's voice.



A strong tool that needed a path to launch.

Content Coach

Writes and checks copy in Veeam's voice.



Built by Content Strategy. Live globally in November.

MISS

#1

Pilot 3rd-party tech

6 quick-win content use cases

4+ months

business cases, vendor shortlist, trial approval

On par or better

our internal systems, including Content Coach, matched it

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Johannes Kuhnle

Marketing AI Architect

January 2026

My first additional headcount

A builder

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Marketing Agent Accelerator Pipeline

01 **Idea**

02 **Prototype**

03 **Pilot**

04 **Production**

Starts with a complete business case



The dream



2-week sprints



WIP limits



Agile developer style

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What Johannes built.

99% CUSTOMER STORY AGENT	**Writes customer story drafts** faster: 2 weeks to a 30-minute first draft	**On track to save about $35K this year**
2x SEO BLOG AGENT	**Drafts SEO blog posts** output with the same headcount	**Manual handoffs: 4 to 1**
$425K SDR AGENT	**Acts on marketing signals** opportunity sourced from a marketing signal	**Built in under 4 weeks**

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MISS

#2

SME timelines slip

weekly reviews, and SMEs had other work

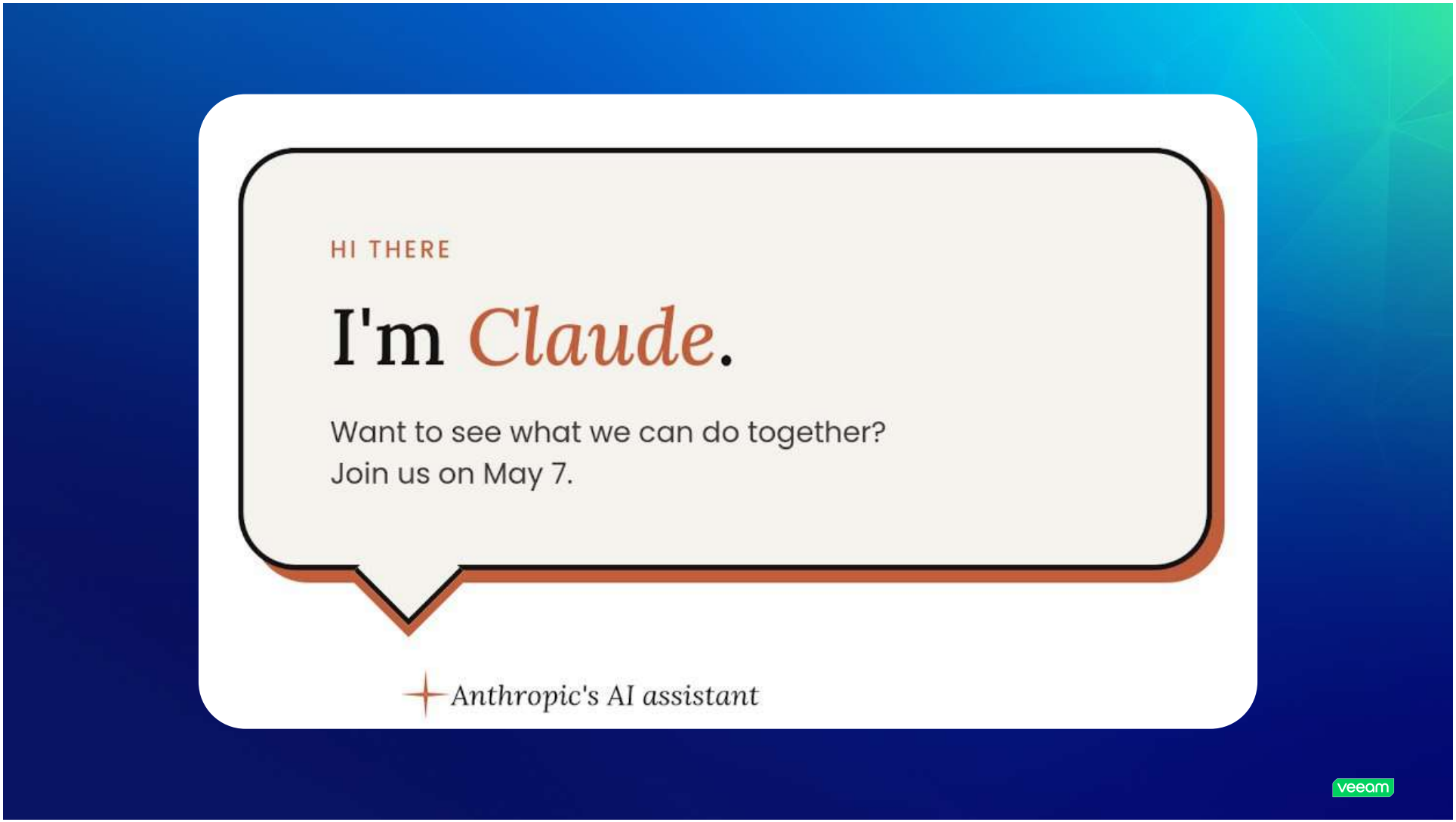
One platform.

few integrations, everything built in Copilot

A bottleneck of two

two people, two builds at a time

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HI THERE
I'm Claude.
Want to see what we can do together?
Join us on May 7.
Anthropic's AI assistant

Enablement became the focus.

Strategic alignment

Governance

Enablement

Outcomes

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Early signs it was working.

3x+

Content Coach usage in one quarter with Claude addition

10

1:1s booked with our intern after June enablement session

MISS

#3

2 markethons planned

our rebrand of the hackathon

They never happened

conflicting priorities and schedules

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Global marketing shared goals.

EVERY FTE

1 AI certification

EVERY TEAM

1 high-impact workflow, shipped

Individual

Team

Business

AI Adoption Curve

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Tracking AI pilots via spreadsheet



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Just a spreadsheet.

Team-level workflows only.

Shared by more than one person or team.



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Pilot management system on a page

3 PILOT TYPES

- Functional-led
- Functional-led, Marketing AI supported
- Marketing AI-led

READ

AI Pilot Playbook

How piloting works: stages, checkpoints, the rules, when the process applies. Nothing to fill in.

When: always. Start here.

WORK

AI Pilot Project Plan

One per workflow, duplicated from the template. Workflow diagram, success criteria, pilot window, checkpoints, readout.

When: Prototype and Pilot.

SHIP

Workflow Handoff Guide

The shipping manifest: overview, install, run, demo, success criteria. Joins the GMO AI Hub skill library.

When: required at Production entry.

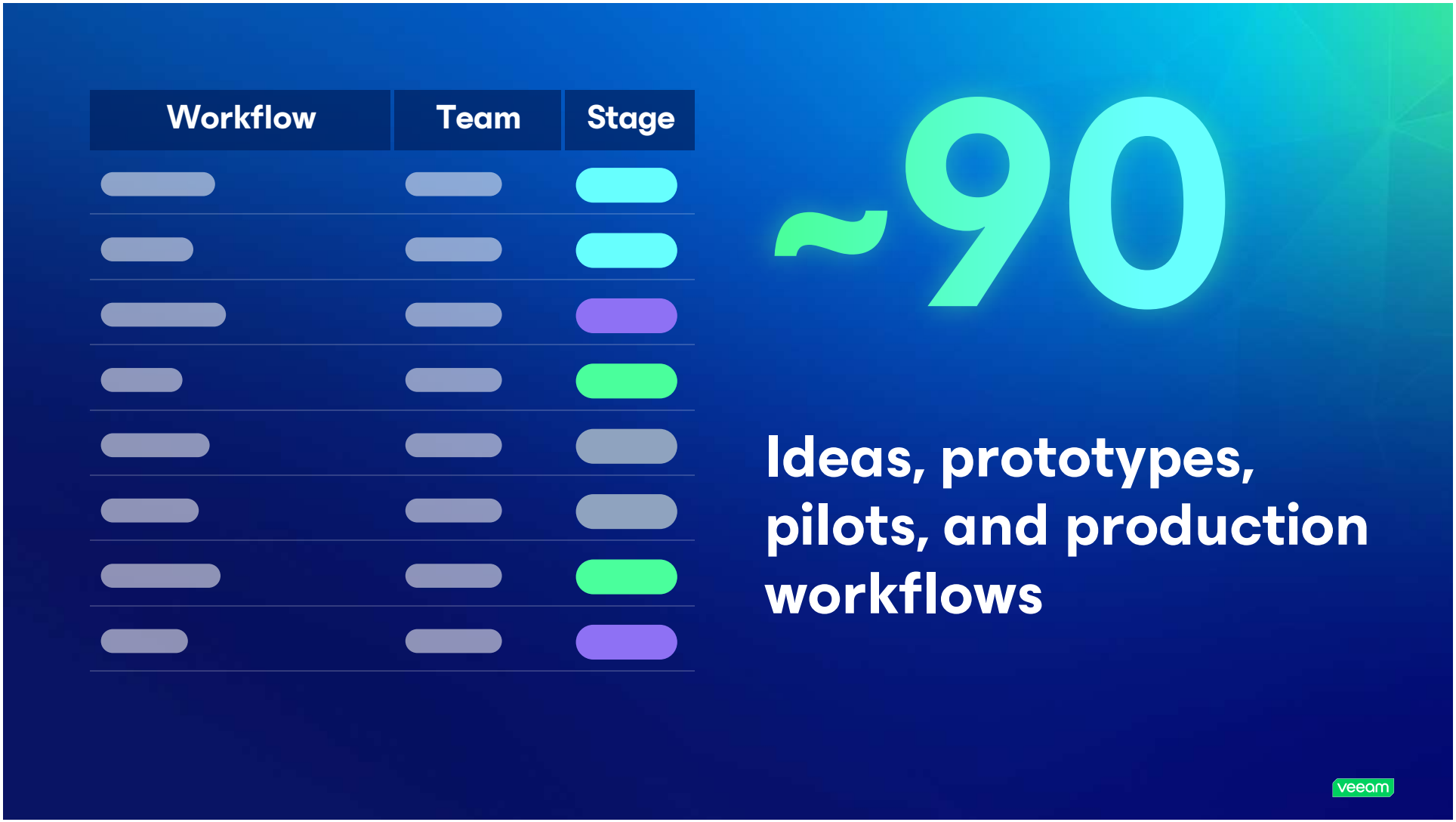
TRACK

GMO AI Pilot Tracker

One row per workflow, always current. At Identified, your row is the business case.

When: Identified onward.

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Workflow
Team
Stage
~90
Ideas, prototypes, pilots, and production workflows
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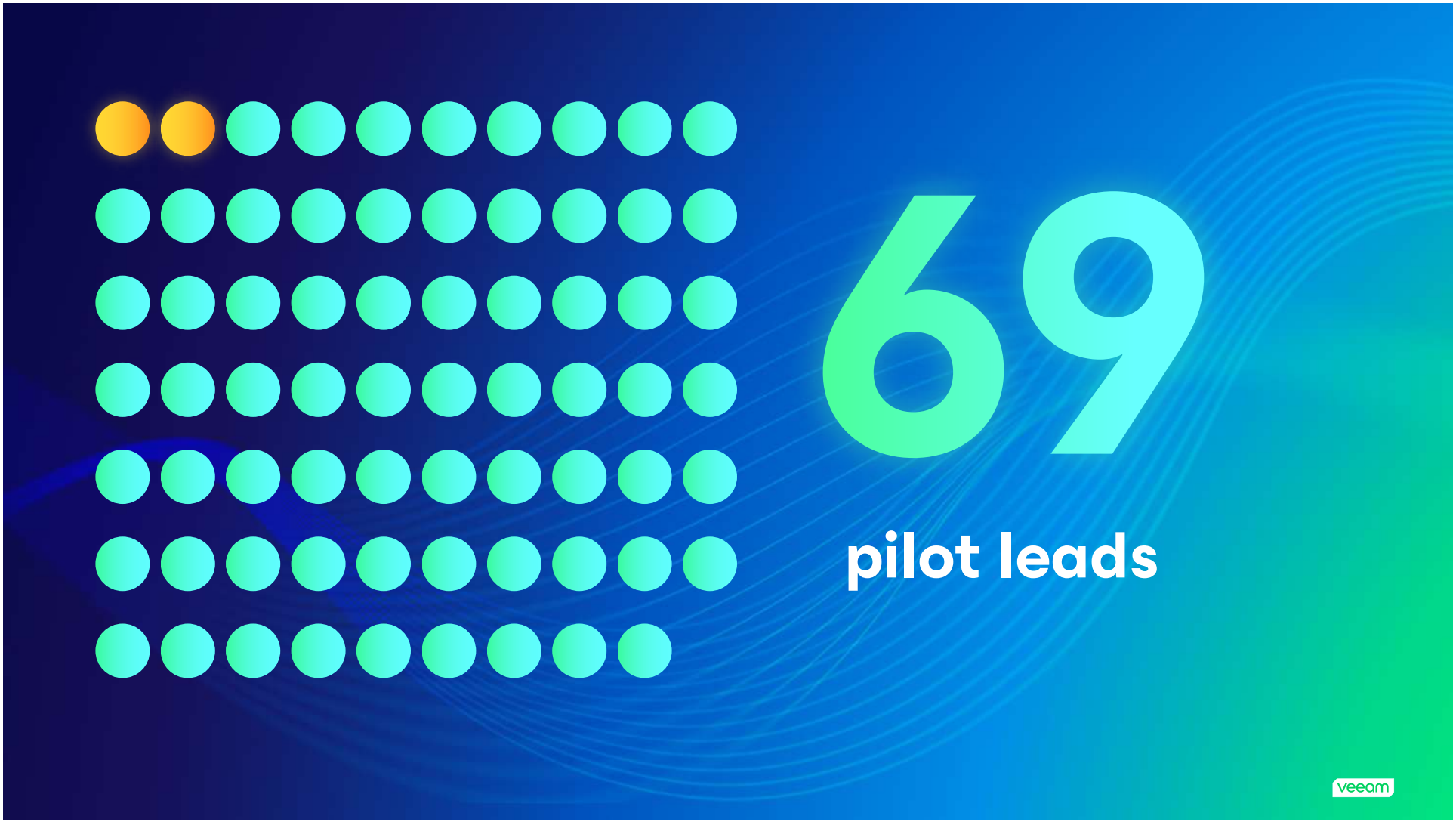
Jessica



Johannes

2

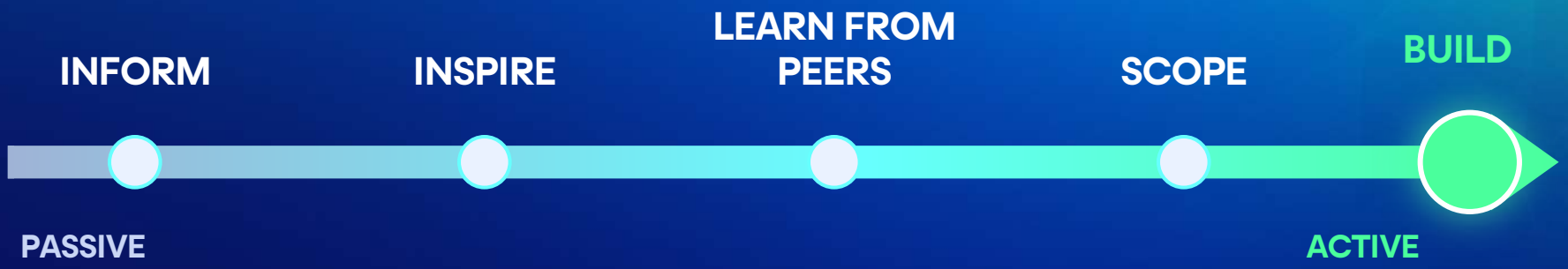
pilot leads


69
pilot leads
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Two people did not build this.

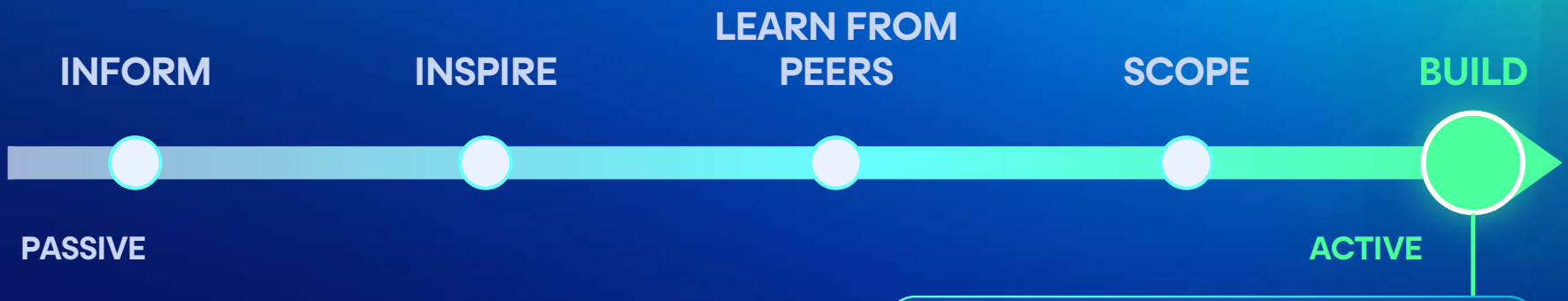
Enablement explains the gap.

From informing to building.



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From informing to building.



Every other format brings you to knowing and wanting.

Hands-on labs is the only one that gets you building.

HANDS-ON LABS

90 min, twice

One small team at a time
A skill built live
Everyone leaves with a task of their own

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Hands-on labs



1 of 7 had ever built a skill

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Hands-on labs

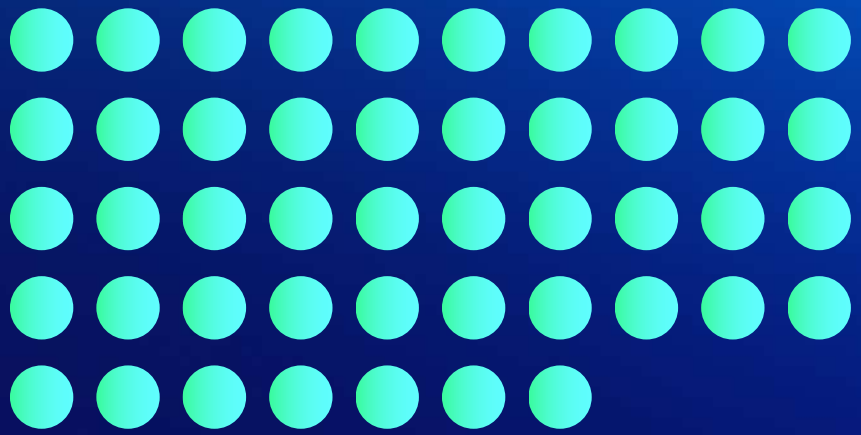


7 of 7, a week later

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The agents saved us time and money.

The agents saved us money.



The labs made

47

more builders

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A central team taking tickets wouldn't have known these problems well enough.

The people living with them did.

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BUILT BY THE CREATIVE STUDIO TEAM

Self-service design, for everyone.



Banner generator

Includes all resizing and variations



Collateral generator

Create and edit in layout, no design skills needed.

0

tokens to run
the HTML apps

1 skill and 4 apps, built with Claude Code

ALSO BUILT

Global PPT creator Claude skill

Badge generator HTML app

Technical diagram kit HTML app

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Surprises from inside the function.

GLOBAL CAMPAIGNS

Analysis to skill



A loop that turns what works into a skill

Now launching org-wide

ONLINE EVENTS

~100



automated emails sorted and routed

Built by the team

CREATIVE STUDIO

1-3 min

30+ min before

now

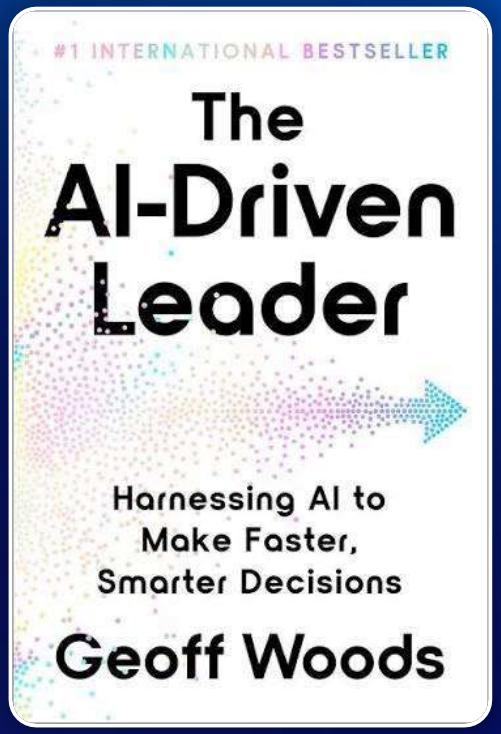
to break a big Jira request into tasks

Foundation of Atlas

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The builders started leading.

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It started as a book club conversation.

Now it's a working agent.

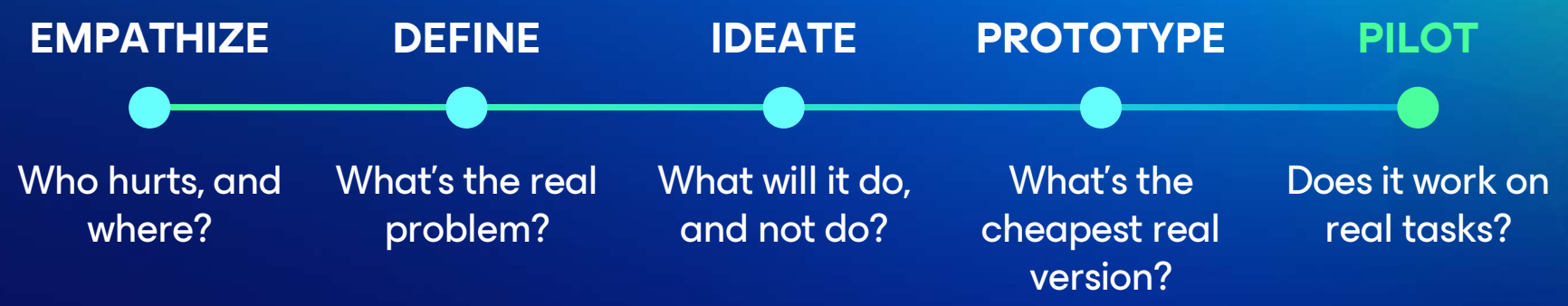
AdScribe Paid ad copy

Built by Elizaveta, Paid Digital.
Google, Meta, LinkedIn and Bing.

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WHAT ELIZAVETA TAUGHT

AI Exchange: Design thinking with AI



None of it needed permission.
It needed a gap worth closing.

ELIZAVETA, ON BUILDING ADSCRIBE

Stages follow the Stanford d.school model, adapted by Elizaveta (Pilot in place of Test).

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AND THEN THERE'S IRINA

Irina Dorokhova

Customer Marketing Manager

THEN

"I'm too late to catch up..."



NOW

"I just became someone willing to experiment."

Monthly AI newsletter

Led a session for Bucharest interns

On top of her day job

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IT SPREAD.

WHAT'S NEXT

Roadmaps by team

Council members lead what's next.



FROM OUR LABS

Team-led sharing

Monthly, run by the team members.



Spark and Scale

EMEA field marketing

OUTSIDE MARKETING

AI Council launched

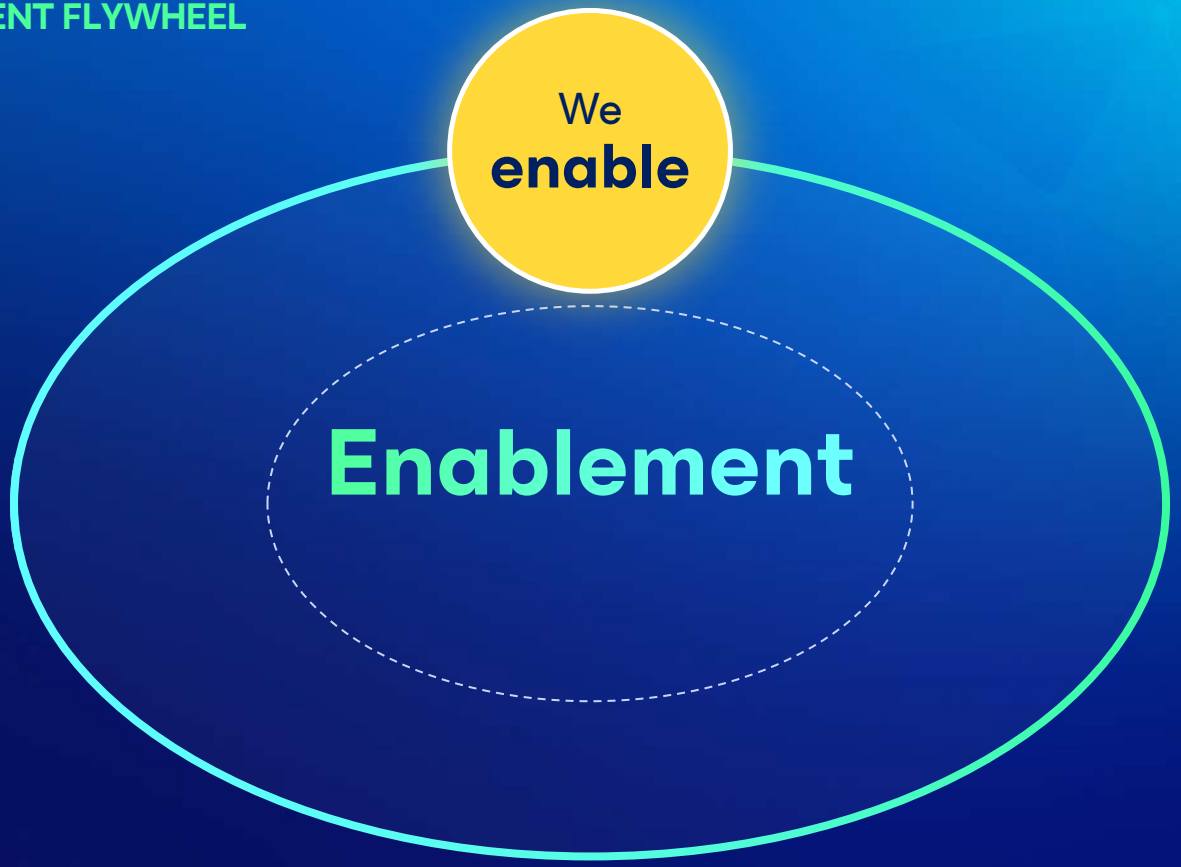
Modeled after ours. Launched last month.



People & Culture

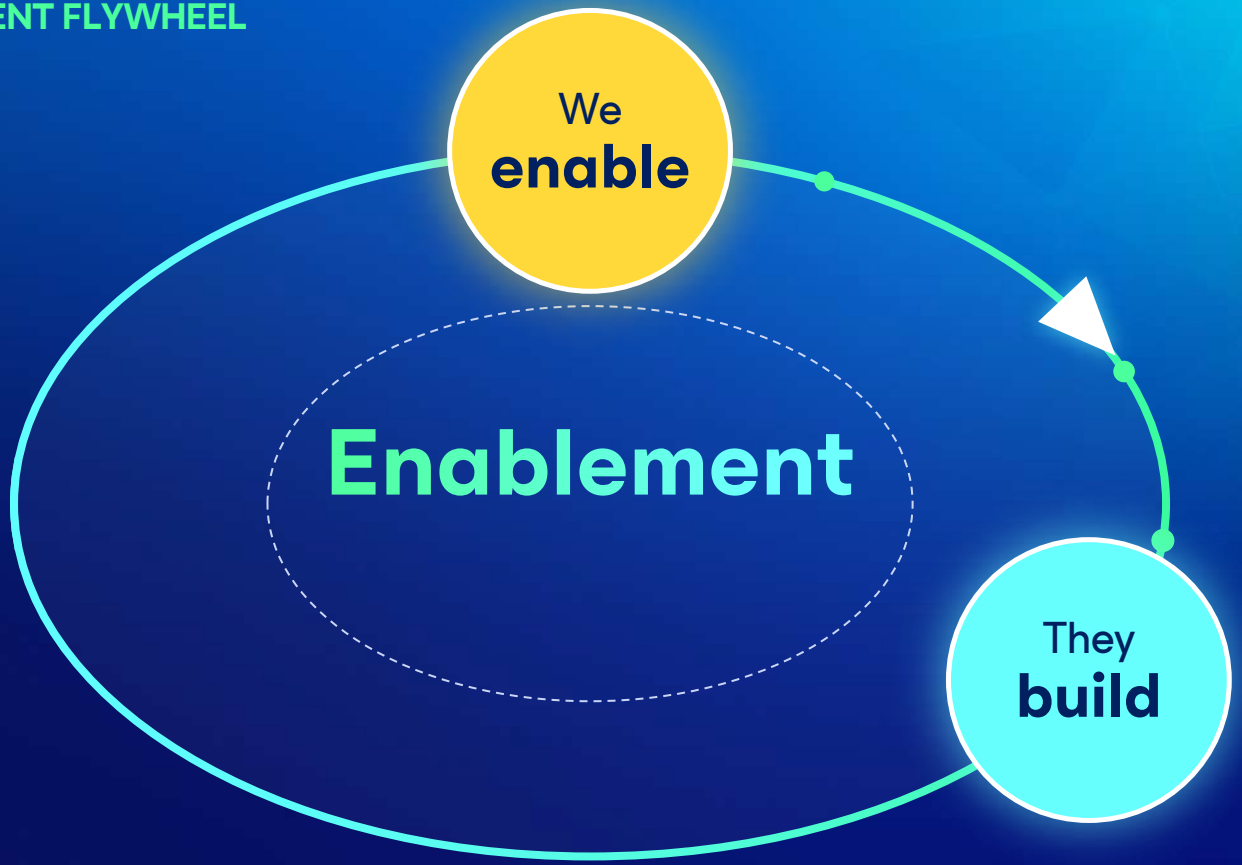
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THE ENABLEMENT FLYWHEEL

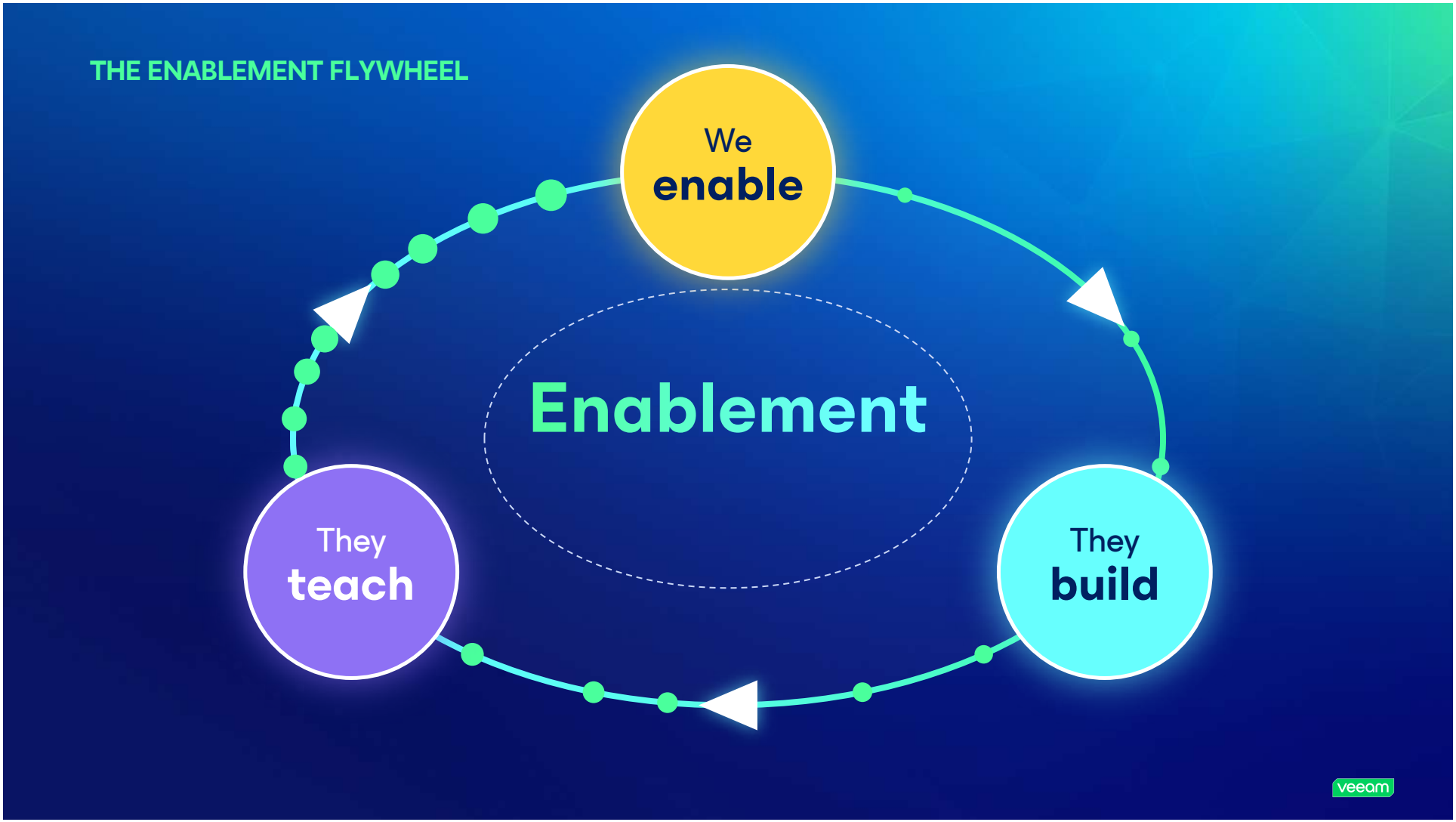


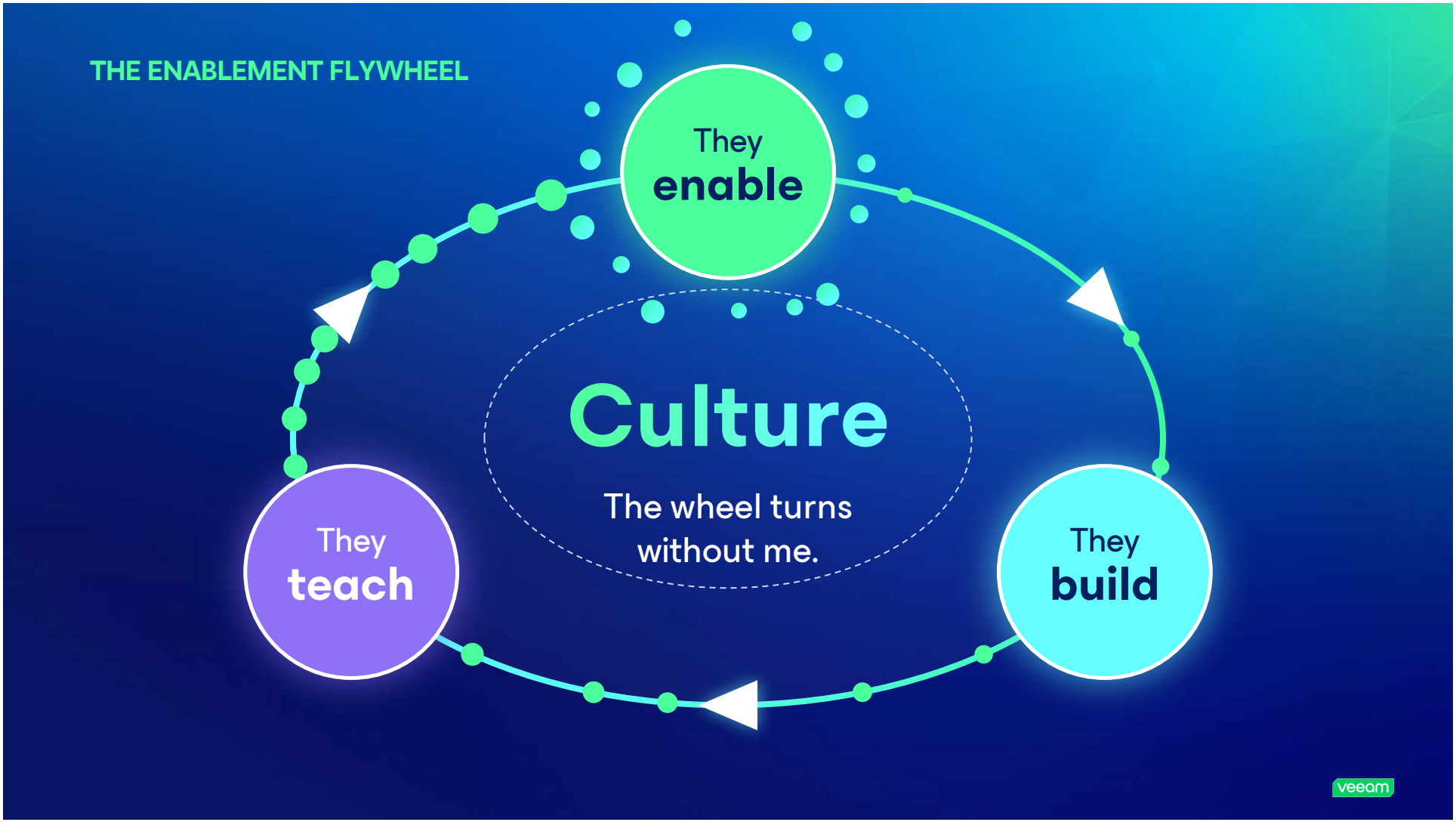
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THE ENABLEMENT FLYWHEEL



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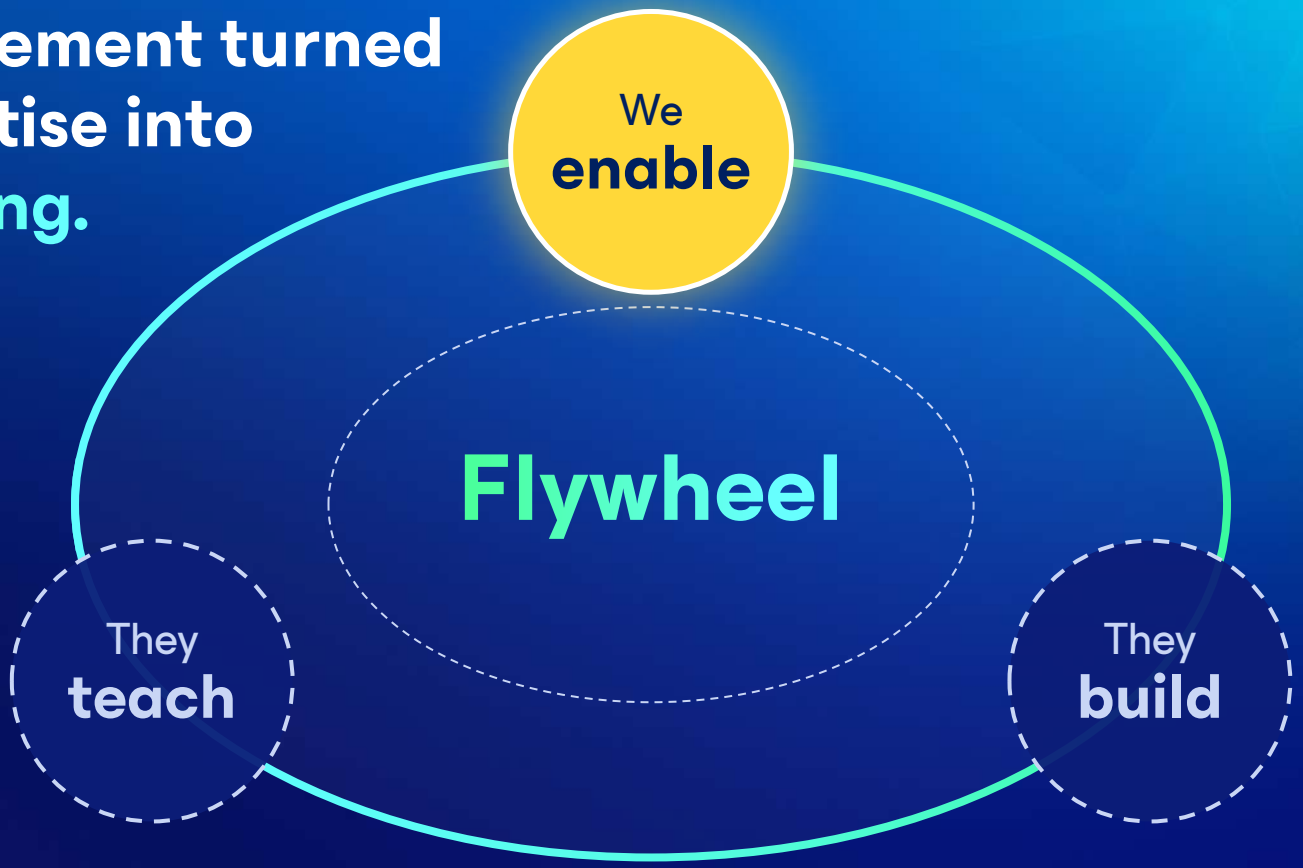

THE ENABLEMENT FLYWHEEL
We
enable
Enablement
They
build
They
teach
veeam


THE ENABLEMENT FLYWHEEL
They enable
They build
They teach
Culture
The wheel turns without me.
veeam

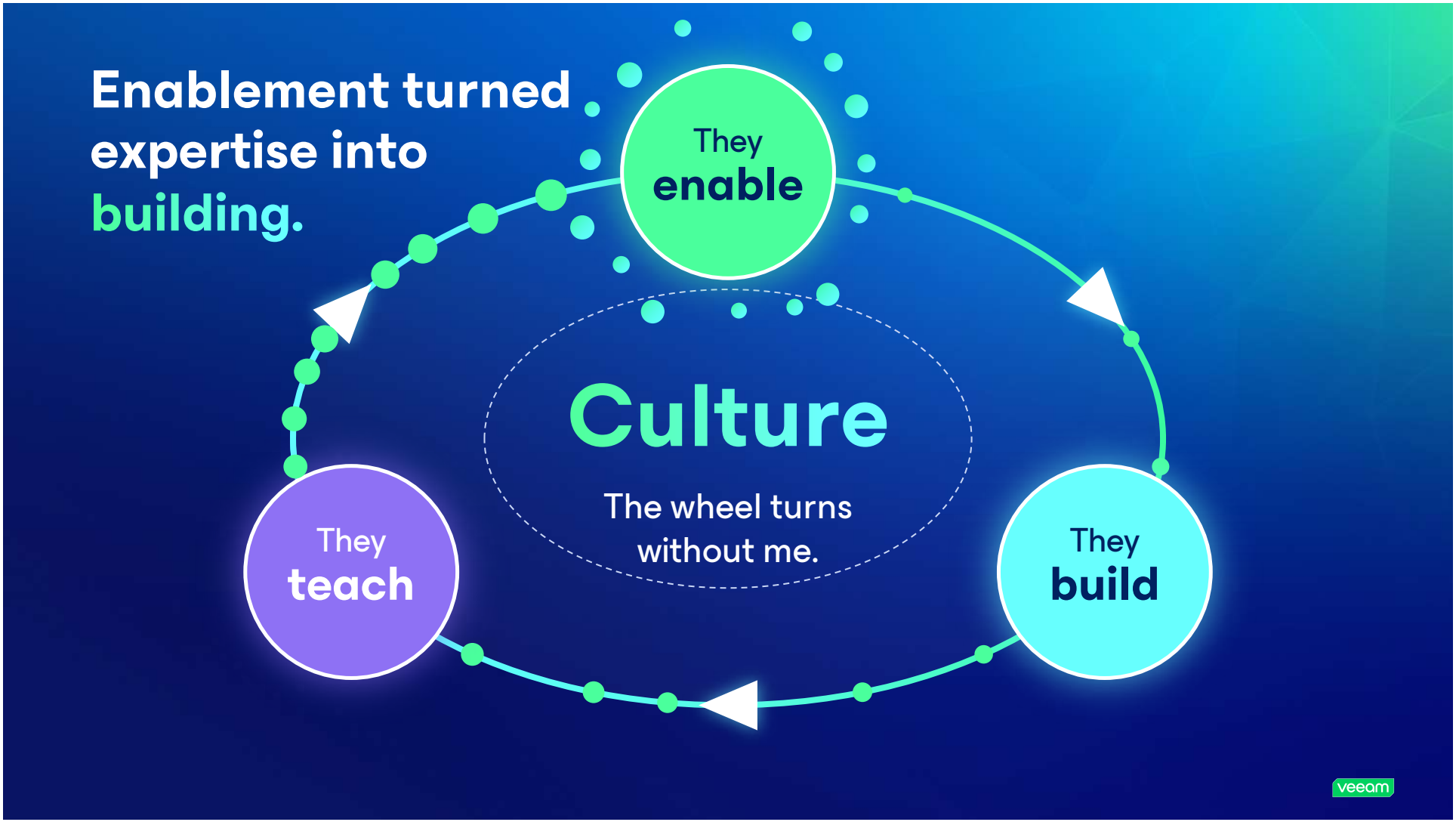
I was wrong about the fix.

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Enablement turned expertise into building.



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Enablement turned expertise into building.
They enable
Culture
The wheel turns without me.
They build
They teach
veeam

A builder's job is not to build everything.

It's to make building learnable.

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Marketing AI leading the work between teams.



Harold

Web pages

Intake → Jira → 21 skills → Figma → PMM approves

Product marketing, content strategy and digital experience, in one flow

Atlas

Jira orchestration

1



one intake, 13+ tickets

2.5 hrs

saved per marketer, per campaign request



EventIQ

Exec briefings

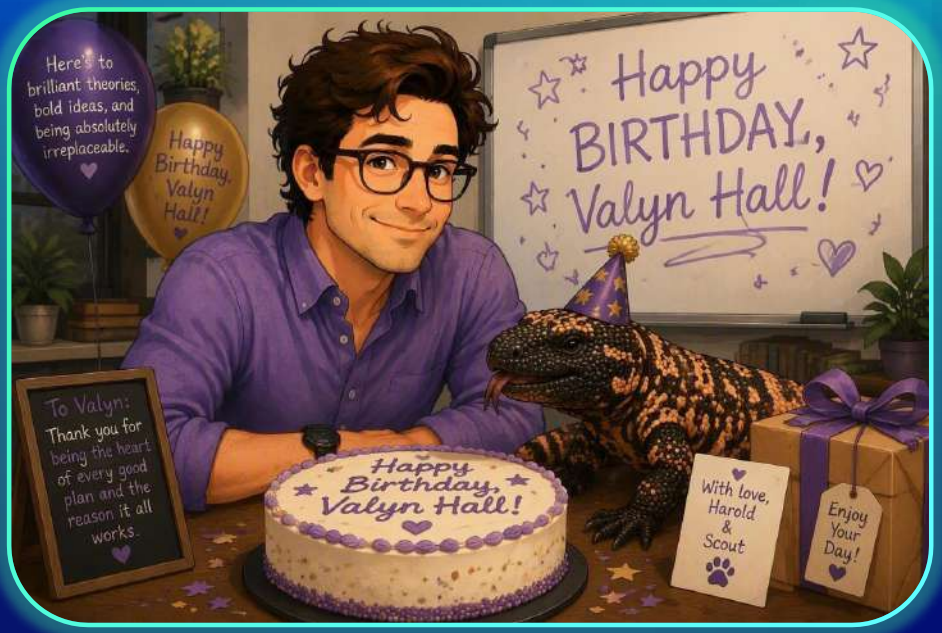
Any file → Briefing per guest → Marketer reviews → Exec's phone

60s account briefs per guest for exec review + email follow up (next phases)

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Harold off the clock





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The culture moved. THEN the workflows shipped.

Practitioners who do the work



System designers who build the systems and guardrails

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VEEAM GLOBAL MARKETING

70 digital teammates

across nine teams

12 All of Veeam

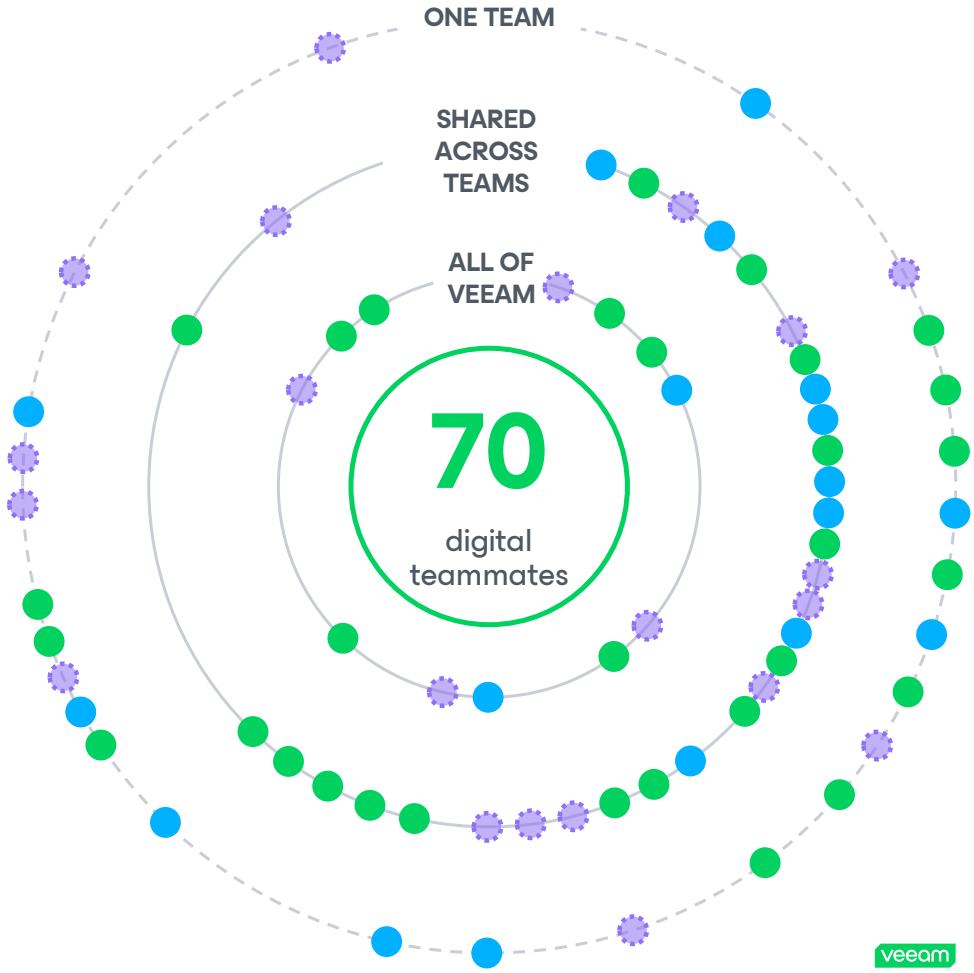
32 Shared across teams

26 Embedded in one team

STAGE

- Production 31
- Pilot 18
- Prototype 21

Source: GMO AI Workflow Tracker, 6 October 2026.



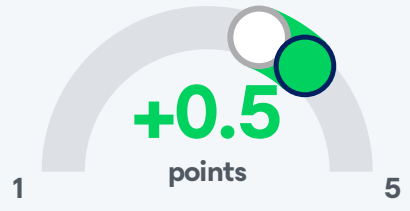
One year later.

Marketing AI survey, 2025 vs 2026

AI CONFIDENCE

average, out of 5

3.47 → 3.95



THE #1 BARRIER

training

48% → 11%

Now: integration, time and budget, too many changes at once



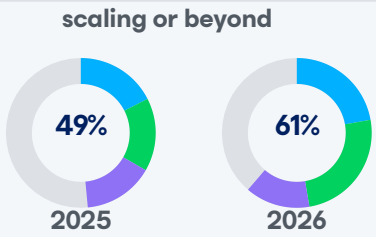
OPERATIONALIZING

not just experimenting

16% → 25%

Grew by more than half

- Scaling
- Operationalizing
- Transforming



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VEEAM GLOBAL MARKETING

70 digital teammates

across nine teams

12 All of Veeam

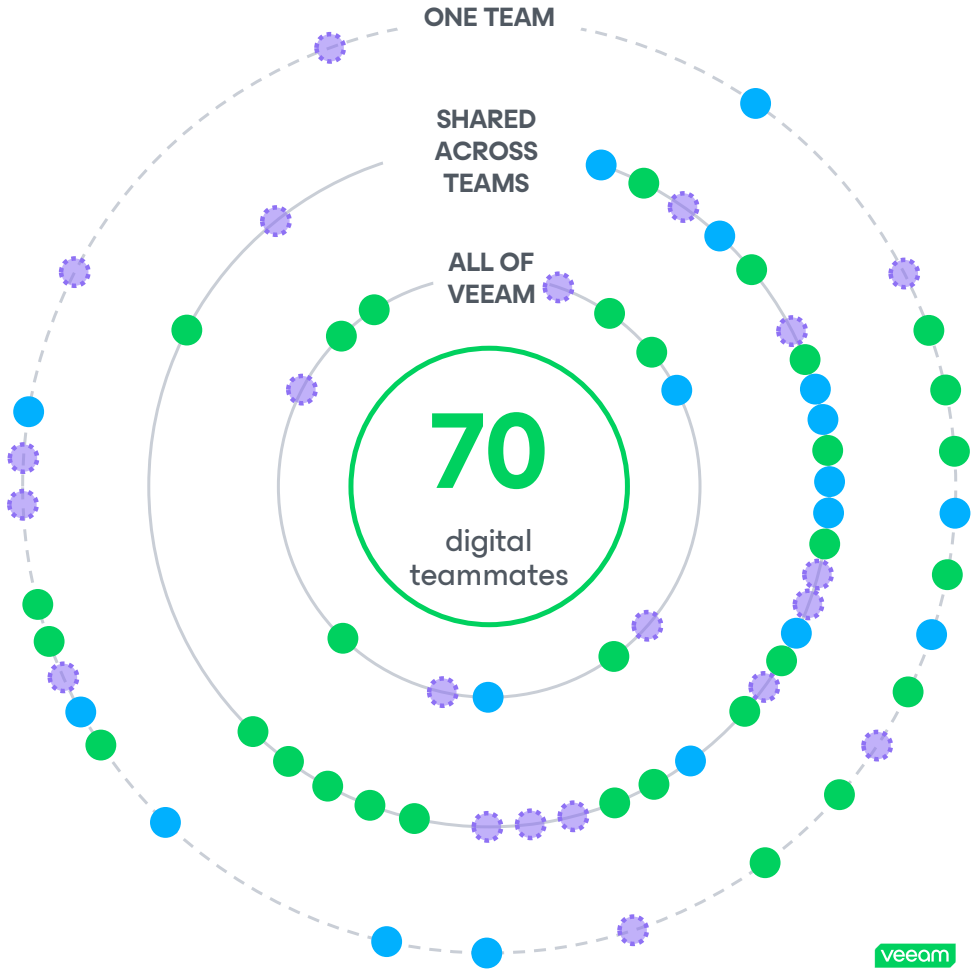
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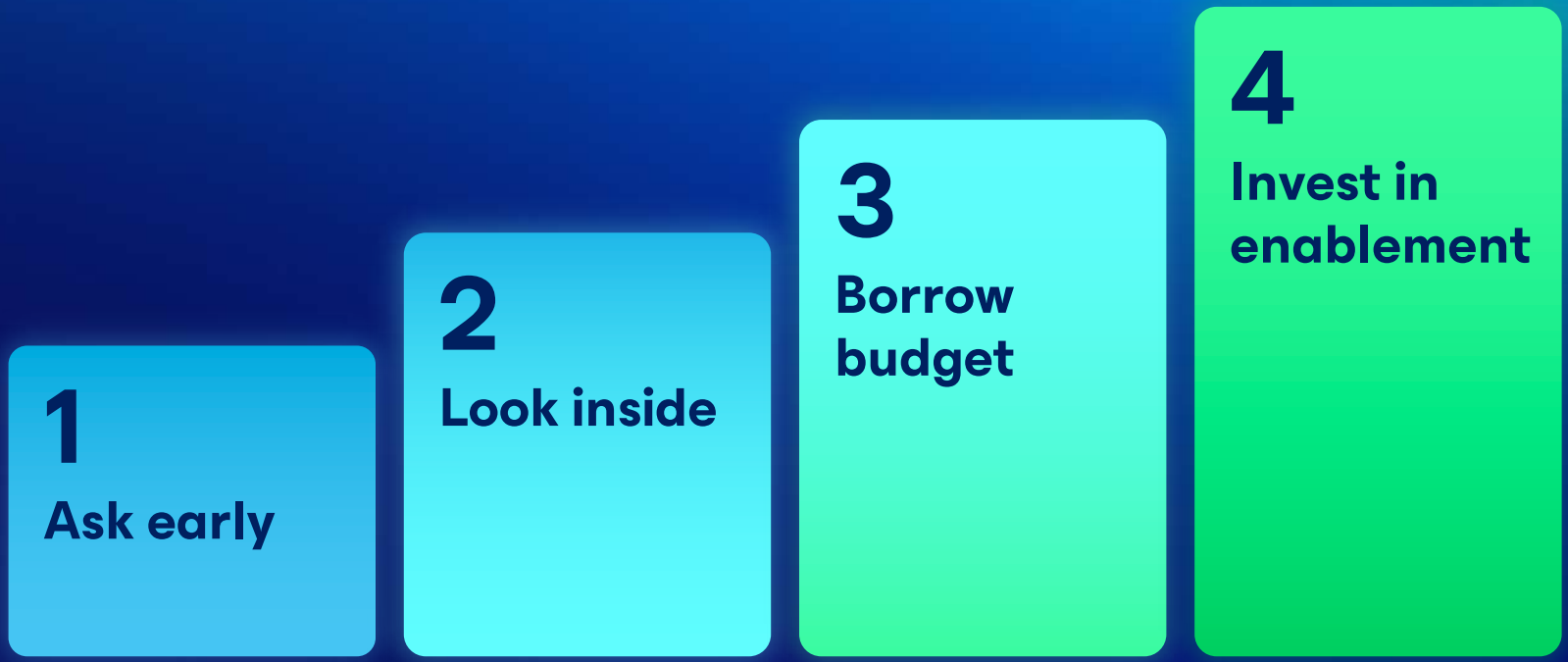
STAGE

- Production 31
- Pilot 18
- Prototype 21

Source: GMO AI Workflow Tracker, 6 October 2026.



No headcount to add? Four moves.



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Build the operating model that lets every function build.

Give your AI leader a team.

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Point most of it at enablement.



- **Enablement**
  Literacy, labs, 1:1s, prototype coaching
- **High-impact builds**
  Cross-functional, complex, no single owner
- **Testing what's next**
  New tools and models for the function

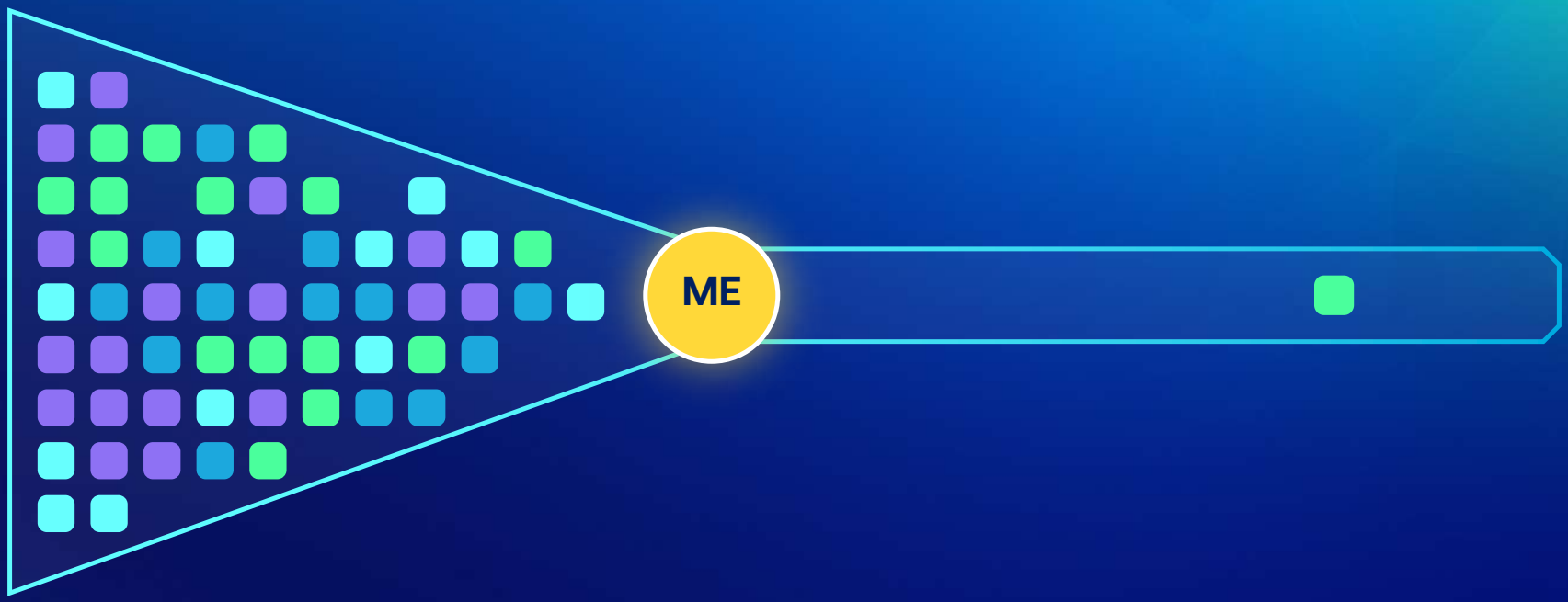
Illustrative split of the team's effort, not time tracking.

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Because you can build so much more when you build builders.

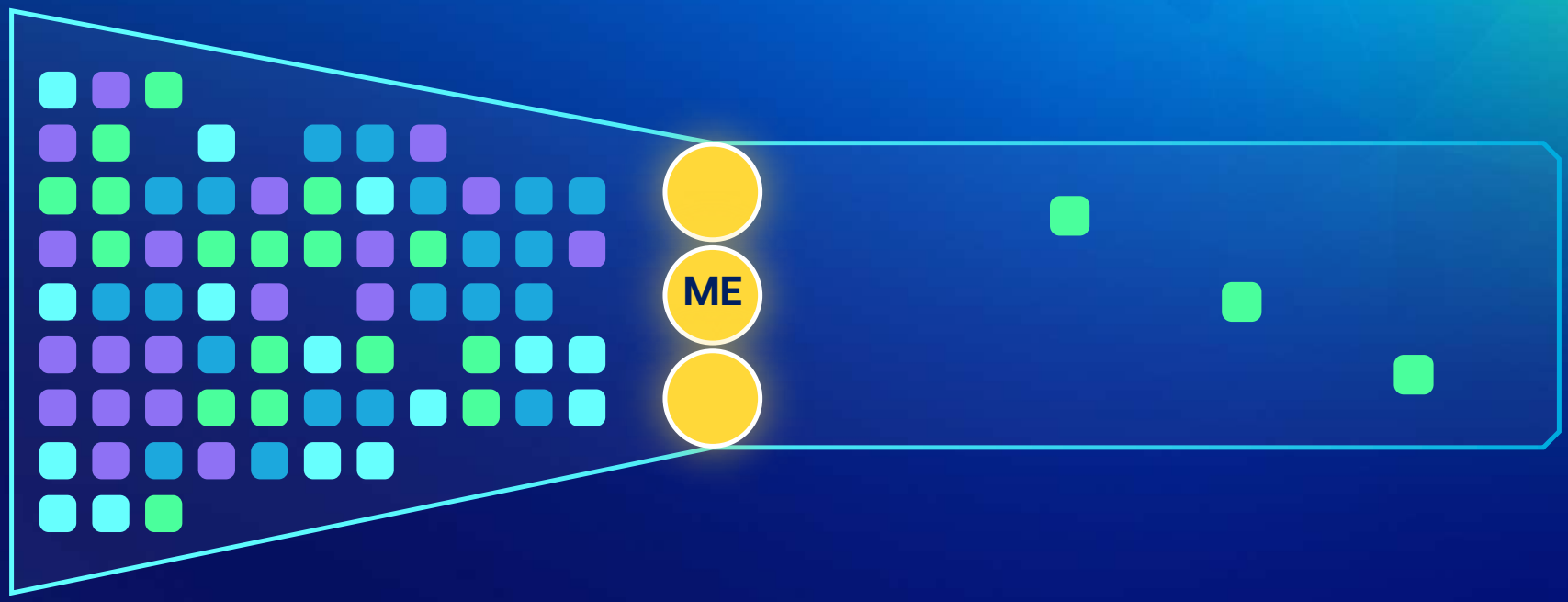
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The bottleneck of one



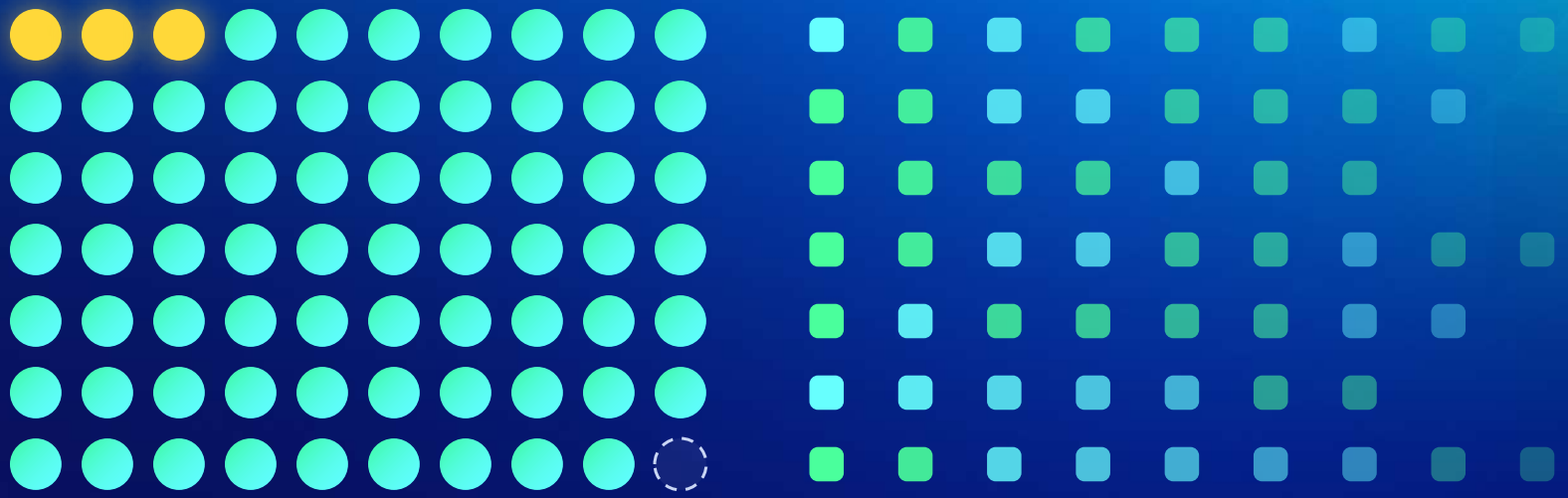
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didn't get solved by two or even three.



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It got solved by sixty-nine and counting...



SHIPPED

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Invest in making builders.

- My team
- The builders, and counting



Thank you.

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MAICON FORWARD

JESSICA HREHA

Director, Marketing AI Transformation

Veeam Software

THANK YOU! WE APPRECIATE YOUR SESSION FEEDBACK.

#MAICON26